Between the Heartbeats

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31010648.

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General Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow & Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

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Cameos from other characters as usual, But I don't like tagging every single one, side-series, Werewolf AU, werecat au, Alternate Universe - Modern with Magic, exploring trauma, Some angst, Some Fluff, Slice of Life

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Part 2 of Heartbeats AU

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by catrasredemption (dimensionhoppingrose)

Summary

A side series to Always A Heartbeat From Me, exploring what happened in the time gaps between chapter, and beyond chapter three.

Notes

Yeah, so I'd been playing with the idea of something like this for awhile, and then the title just sort of popped into my head and - I mean, how can I ignore that? It's perfect.

Anyway, the chapters are self contained (and not 20k words good lord what was I on when I wrote Always), and about anything between chapters one and two (Catra's college years), two and three (the five years between the end of chapter two and Catra getting pregnant), and of course some family fluff feat. Finn and Callie (TWIN SHENANIGANS FTW). They're not even remotely in any order - I'm just writing as the inspiration strikes. I'm already thinking about Callie and Finn and Finn's gender exploration and Callie biting the first person who misgenders her sibling (she is her Mama's daughter), and I can't promise regular updates or anything - which is why the story is marked as complete. It's just something I'm doing for fun.

Anyway, summary for this chapter: Adora trying to figure out her complicated feelings about transforming without being scared of getting stuck as a wolf

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1

Adora shot up, a scream lodged in her throat. Her arms flailed wildly, desperately, until a firm hand grabbed one of her wrists, and a light flicked on.

"Adora! *Adora*!"

Her head snapped around, eyes focusing on her frazzled girlfriend. Catra gently grasped Adora's face in her hands, squeezing. "It's okay," she reminded her, leaning in to kiss her forehead. "It's okay. You're okay. Remember?"

Okay. She was okay. She nodded, taking a few gasping breaths. She was okay. Catra pulled her into a tight hug, all but crawling into her lap. It was the best way to help Adora stay grounded – keeping her physically aware that she was *there*, with Catra, in her own body. She wasn't a wolf. She was okay.

Catra purred, her chest rumbling, her cheek nuzzling into Adora's neck. "Do you want to talk about it?"

Adora shook her head. She didn't *want* to, and in that moment she wasn't sure words were work. She still struggled with that sometimes.

"Okay. Come on." Catra nudged Adora to lie back, nestling on her chest and resuming her purring. Sometimes it was all she could do. And Adora loved her for it.

"You seem perfectly fine," Angella said thoughtfully as examined Adora. "You could probably try transforming again."

"Oh." Adora knew her responding smile was in fact *not* a smile. "That's... That's great."

Angella leaned back in her seat to examine Adora. "Why do I get the feeling you're not as enthused as you seem?" she asked dryly. Adora really liked Angella – she was blunt and never minced words. She was like a slightly more reserved Marlena.

Adora tried not to think about that too much.

"What. What if I get stuck again?" she asked quietly, staring at her hands.

"Then Catra has our phone numbers and can call if something goes wrong. And you'll have her to help you until we find a way to change you back," Angella explained calmly. "But I highly doubt you'll get stuck like that."

"But it's. it's possible, isn't it? It happens."

"It does," Angella agreed. "Usually when someone is improperly raised or trained to control their transformation. You're neither of those things, however."

"But what *if*." Adora stressed the word, trying to ignore the tears in her eyes. Angella regarded her quietly for a long moment.

"Have you spoken to anyone about your fears?" she asked.

"I don't need to," Adora said immediately. "I'm fine."

"No one would judge you if you weren't," Angella pointed out. "You've been through a lot."

"No, I. I'm fine." She had to be fine. Catra was already so stressed out trying to take care of her. She couldn't put *more* on her. It wouldn't be fair. Angella frowned, but didn't push.

"If you change your mind, you can always reach out."

Adora nodded, forcing a smile. "Thank you. For everything."

"Dont act like this is the last time youre going to see me," Angella says with a small chuckle. "Glimmer will break Catra and talk her into a family dinner eventually."

Adora laughed. Catra, apparently, had been dodging invitations to Spella family dinners since the they had met in college. Something about not needing *another* set of parents. Glimmer had taken this as a challenge.

Catra was at her desk, typing away. It was weird seeing her so professional, working an office job. Part of Adora still felt like they were fifteen. Like time had stopped. She had missed *so much*. She tried to force a smile, not wanting to dwell on that. Time was too precious for her to waste.

"Hey . Ready to go?"

"Yeah," Catra murmured, hitting a few keys. "Just let me finish this"…

Adora watched as she finished and shut her computer down, gathering her stuff up. The split gaze that met Adora's was older — certainly not fifteen anymore. The ten years they had spent apart had been a lifetime for her.

"All right, let's"—

Adora gently took her by the waist and leaned in, kissing her. It was chaste —just a simple kiss. But it was something they'd both thought they'd never had again, and they were still getting used to having it back.

"Get a room," Glimmer said as she walks by . Catra flipped her off without even looking.

They stopped for burgers on their way home —Adora was still indulging her random food cravings. She'd get over the novelty of human food again eventually, but right now she just wanted a burger and fries and a milkshake.

"I feel sick just watching you," Catra said, mostly teasing, as Adora stuck a fry in the milkshake and popped it into her mouth. They took turns driving, because Adora was still getting used to that as well. She had driven to the office for her "checkup", and Catra was driving home now, leaving Adora free to tear into her food.

"You're just jealous."

"Mmmm, yeah, definitely jealous of you and your soggy potato tubes."

Adora determinedly stuck another fry into the milkshake, then her mouth. Catra rolled her eyes, shaking her head. "I can't believe I kiss you."

"You looooooooooove me."

"For *some* reason."

They had a quiet night, putting on some a show in the background while Catra helped Adora study. Apparently being hostage for three years and stuck as a wolf for seven didn't excuse Adora from needing a high school degree to do anything. She also wanted to go to college, although what she *wanted* to do with her life, she had no idea. She was still having a hard time readjusting to the idea that she *had* a life again.

"You don't have to do everything at once," Catra reminded her when she expressed her frustration. She was taking online courses, and currently entirely vexed by the existence of Algebra. "No one is going to judge you if you want to drop Algebra and try again later. You already have a full schedule."

"I'm tired of just sitting around at home while you work all day," Adora said with a small pout. "I want to *do* something."

"You *are* doing something. You're trying to finish high school." Catra kissed her cheek. "Stop being so hard on yourself." Adora glared at

her laptop screen;Catra rolled her eyes. "Melog, help me out here."

The shrunken cat guardian hopped onto the back of the couch, strolling along and leaning in to lick Adora's cheek. She laughed despite herself. "Okay , okay. But I really do want to try and finish this class."

"Okay , let's start over then"…

Adora was abruptly awoken by a slap to the face.

She jolted up, blinking rapidly , before she managed to focus Catra. Melog had crawled on top of her, trying to keep her down and wake her up as she thrashed about, whimpering in her sleep.

"Catra?Catra!"

Adora dodged another swing and ducked, gently shaking her girlfriend by the shoulder. Catra's eyes finally flew open, a small scream dying on her lips. Melog shrunk down to let Adora gather Catra up, hugging her tight. Catra curled into Adora's arms.

"Sorry ,"she whispered, voice thick with tears. "I'm sorry , I"…

"Sssshhh."Adora rocked her gently . "It' s okay. You're okay ."

Catra didn't like talking about her dreams, but she had told Adora enough to make a guess. The worst one was always the burning room. Flames and smoke and suffocating. It sounded eerily like what Adora had experienced before Shadow Weaver had taken her. But no one could figure out how *Catra* could possibly know about that.

"Okay?"she prompted after a moment. Catra nods into her neck.

"Sorry ,"she whispered again.

"It' s okay,"Adora said. "Everything is okay ."

Catra continued to cling to Adora as they lied back down. This was why Adora had to be okay. She talked to Catra about things, because she had her own trauma and it was important for them to talk. But the fear of transforming was stupid, and Catra didnt need that on her mind along with everything else. Adora *needed* to be okay, or Catra would start burying things again.

Adora kissed the top of Catra's head, hugging her tight. "It's okay," she repeated as they settled back in to sleep. "You're okay."

It wasnt that she didnt *want* to transform. She did. She could feel the wolf *burning* inside her, desperate to run, to feel the air in its fur, *exist*. She wanted it more than anything. She *needed* it like she needed air.

And yet her hands trembled when she thought about it. Her mind raced. Her pulse quickened, her breathing got short. She knew what a panic attack looked like. She could spot the beginnings of one. It was enough to put her off trying again for another day.

"We should go running this weekend," Catra said lazily, head resting in Adora's lap. Adora's jaw clenched.

"On two legs or four?" she asked, trying to be casual. Catra hummed, rolling to look up at her.

"I'm feeling four legs, but it's up to you. Have you tried transforming yet?"

"No. It doesnt feel right, I guess. Nerves, you know?"

It wasnt entirely a lie. A purr built in Catra's chest as she pressed her face into Adora's shirt. The purring always made Adora feel calm. "Maybe we should do four, then. Cant let the wolf get out of shape with all those burgers you're eating."

Adora gave her a small shove, laughing. "*Fine*."

She could try. She needed to try. She needed to get over this. She *could* get over this. It would be fine.

Saturday morning found them in the Driluths' backyard. It was the best place to go for a run, and even better for practice. They'd grown up practicing in this backyard and getting to know these woods. Melog was slinking around the edges of the yard, waiting for Catra and Adora to stop snarking at each other and get a move on. They made a loud noise, and Catra rolled her eyes.

"All right, all right, let's go."

Adora watched her change—watched as she hunched over, as her fur and claws grew. It was fine, she reminded herself, taking a deep breath. She would be fine. Everything was going to be okay. She closed her eyes, and tried to focus. Changing used to be second nature to her. Like riding a bicycle, right? She was a werewolf. This was part of who she was. It was okay.

It was *not* okay.

Panic immediately exploded in Adora's mind. Her heart was racing. A hand closed around her lungs, squeezing the air out of them. She could feel her skin itching as fur tried to grow, her bones trying to shift, a snout growing from her face…

But she was stuck. She was stuck halfway between forms and panicking. *She was stuck*, she had messed it up, she couldn't do this, something was wrong with her, *she was broken*—

A heavy body tackled Adora, pinning her to the ground. All of her human features snapped back into place with a startling suddenness, so fast that it almost *hurt*. She had half a second to see the sky overhead before her vision was obscured by a giant, brown-furred cat. Catra ducked in to nuzzle her cheek, drying tears Adora hadn't realized had fallen, and purring loud enough for the sound to vibrate through Adora's body.

Adora shuddered, forcing her arms up to hug Catra close. She vaguely heard the door opening, and the sound of Lyra calling across the yard. Catra looked up for a moment before refocusing on Adora.

Adora choked on a sob. "I'm okay," she whispered shakily. "I'm okay."

Lyra helped her sit up; Catra adjusted herself so she could sit in Adora's lap, and Adora pressed her face into Catra's scruff. Lyra rubbed her back gently, encouraging her to breathe. She was gasping, hiccuping as she did her best to comply. "I'm okay." She wasn't. "I'm okay." She wasn't.

They sat in silence for a few minutes. Adora slowly regained control of her breathing, although she was still clinging to Catra and sniffling. She kept flexing her fingers through Catra's fur, just to feel the movement. To know she still had fingers.

"What happened?" Lyra asked, voice ringing with concern. Adora hated that. She didn't want people to worry about her. She was *fine*. She had to be fine. Everyone needed her to be fine—

Melog gently bonked the side of her head with their snout, mewling. She wondered if they knew how she felt—not like they knew Catra, but something similar. Adora had basically grown up around Melog, after all.

"I." She clenched her jaws for a moment, fighting to get the words out. "I'm scared," she finally whispered. "I'm scared to transform."

Catra pulled away just slightly to look at her. Adora steadfastly ignored her gaze. Lyra brushed Adora's hair back; Adora leaned into the touch, letting out a shaking breath. "Why?" Lyra asked after a moment.

"Because. Because I'm afraid of getting stuck again. I thought if maybe I... I just did it, it would be fine, but I started changing, and…

and"…

Lyra tugged her into a tight hug from behind. Catra was still purring, but Adora heard the subtle shift in pitch. She was upset now. "I…I'm sorry, I"—

She cut off abruptly when Catra head-butted her right under the chin. It forced her jaw shut with an audible click and almost hurt. "I *believe*," Lyra said slowly, "Catra is trying to say that there's nothing to apologize for."

Catra purred in agreement. "I'm trying not to be a burden," Adora whispered. "I know I already make things difficult because I need so much, and just being alive makes things difficult for everyone else and"—

Another slightly too aggressive head butt. "You're *never* a burden," Lyra said firmly, squeezing a little tighter. "You were hurt and and you're traumatized, and that's not something you get over overnight. You need time." Adora's lower lip quivered, but she didn't say anything. "It's okay to need help, Adora."

"I"…

Catra shifted slightly, and Adora felt her changing back. She missed the warmth of the bulk and fur, but another set of arms around her felt nice. "I still see Mara once a month," she pointed out quietly. "Does that make me a burden?"

"What?" Adora looked down at her, heart jumping into her throat. "No! Of course not. That's *different*"—

"How?" Lyra challenged. "How is Catra needing help for her problems any different from you needing help?"

"It…It just is. Catra went through a lot."

“*God* you're an idiot,” Catra muttered into Adora’s neck. “What do you call being kidnapped and tortured for three years and then running all over creation for seven? A regular Tuesday?”

Adora ducked her head, tears filling her eyes. “I…”

Lyra kissed Adora’s temple. “We love you, Adora. We want the best for you. You know we won't judge you for whatever you need.”

“I know.”

“Then stop being stupid,” Catra said, ignoring Lyra shoving her shoulder. Adora sighed, resting her head against Catra’s.

“I don't even know where to start.”

“Gee.” The sarcasm was heavy in Catra’s voice. “If only we knew people who actively advocate for shapeshifters and have dedicated their lives to collecting resources and helping them.”

“We've had a list of therapists ready since you moved in with Catra,” Lyra confirmed. Of course they had. Adora smiled to herself. She really did have the best family.

“Thank you.”

“Tea, dearie?”

“Um...no thank you.”

Of all the therapists on the list, Raz had been the one Adora was the most nervous about. She seemed very...eccentric. But she was also the one with the soonest opening (and even that was three weeks after Adora started making calls), so she was the one Adora went to first. There were plenty of others if this didn't work out.

Which didn't stop Adora from nervously ringing her hands together as anxiety pooled in her stomach. Catra was in the waiting room with

Melog. Adora had *really* wanted Catra in the room, but everyone (including Catra) had said it would be best to at least do the first couple appointments alone. She really didn't agree.

"Why don't you tell me a bit about yourself?" Raz prompted. She had a high, reedy voice, wide eyes, and a skin color that just a little too pink to be fully human. Not uncommon; a lot of people chose to use glamor spells to blend in better, but the skin color wasn't even the first thing that stood out about Raz. *That* would be her wild white hair. It almost reminded Adora of Catra's mane.

"Well, I'm um... twenty-five?" She squinted at the wall. "Yeah, twenty-five. I lost a few years, still trying to get back on track."

"What happened?"

Adora chewed on her inner cheek, taking a deep breath. She didn't want to talk about it. But that's what she was here for, wasn't it?

"My parents were killed when I was fifteen"…

She told the stories in starts and stops, pausing to collect herself or try to recall details. So much of it was fuzzy. Raz listened, nodding along, and giving Adora time to collect herself when she was done.

"Have you taken any time to think about it and how you feel?"

Adora opened her mouth to say... hell if she knew. What kind of ridiculous question was that? Of course she thought about it, it was *all* she thought about sometimes, she—

She closed her mouth abruptly. Yeah, she thought about it a lot, and she had nightmares, but everything she'd done since getting home had been about pushing forward and making up for lost time with Catra. She had to be fine for everyone else.

It's okay to need help.

"No," she admitted quietly. "I... I don't want anyone else to know how bad it is. What if they leave?"

"That's quite the low opinion you have of people in your life."

Adora looked up from the floor, meeting Raz's gaze. "What?"

"You think they'd leave you because you have feelings?" Raz asked.

"If... if it was too much for them to handle—"

"Well, that's why you're here, isn't it? To stop it before it becomes too much. Because the people who love you recognized that you needed something they couldn't give. That doesn't mean you're too much for them and you should hide everything. It's all the more reason to talk to them—so they know and can help you find what you need."

Adora stared at her for a moment, slack-jawed. Catra had admitted that her mothers sent her to therapy after the Incident (which was apparently how Catra referred to running away and nearly being slaughtered by a werewolf pack) because they didn't know what else to do, and Catra hadn't known how to help herself at the time. It would have been easy for Cyra and Lyra to just let it go and let Catra deal with things on her own (and Adora could only imagine how *that* would go), but they hadn't. They'd intervened early and gotten her what she needed because they loved her and wanted her to be okay.

"*Oh*." The word escaped Adora in a breathless whisper. Raz smiled, clearly pleased. It was a small breakthrough—the very tippy top of a very big iceberg—but it was a start. Starts were good.

Catra had been staring at the pamphlet in her hands for ten minutes. It was about werewolf support groups—not just for people who had been forcibly changed, but also for people who were scared to

transform for whatever reason. She wondered if that would be helpful for Adora.

And then her mind had carried her elsewhere.

"Is it my fault?" Melog, who was sitting next to her like a guard dog, looked up, chirping in response. "I mean, she changed back and just immediately started shoving everything down, and that was after she heard about how bad things were. What if I made her feel like she couldn't talk to me? Or that I wouldn't be able to handle it? Or"—

Melog got up on their hind legs, rested their front paws on Catra's knees, and licked her cheek. It was a simple gesture, but it snapped her out of the spiral she had been going down. That done, they pressed their head into her chest, mrowling.

"I *know* I'm dumb, okay?" Another mrowl. "Y eah, I know that's not the word you used. I just. I want her to talk to me. I don't want to drive her away because she thinks I'm too fragile or something."

Melog's responding snort was entirely unimpressed. *No one* thought Catra was fragile. She smiled slightly, shoving them off. "Y eah, yeah. You know what I mean."

They did, and it was a valid concern. But Melog knew Adora ~~—~~not like they knew Catra. That was a bond formed by powers beyond either of them. But they knew Adora through years of contact and companionship, and this was perfectly in character for her. Catra just needed time to remember that. And maybe a session with Mara.

Adora made her way back out to the waiting room when she was done. Catra smiled and stood, pulling her into a tight hug. Adora immediately buried her face in Catra's neck, taking a deep breath.

"How'd it go?"

"All right." Adora' s voice was muffled. "I'm tired."

“Get used to that.” It turned out talking about emotions was absolutely draining. “Wanna get some food on the way home?”

Adora tilted her head slightly, revealing one eye and a half smile. “Hamburgers?”

Catra rolled her eyes. “*Fine*.”

Finn

Chapter Summary

Twin time with Finn and Callie

Chapter Notes

Okay I DEFINITELY can't promise updates this fast every time, but the twins demanded to be written and who am I to ignore them?

"Hey Callie"?

The girl looked up from her book, tilting her head. Finn was staring at her between his floppy blond bangs, which constantly hung in his eyes now. Mama kept saying he needed a haircut. Callie agreed. She kept hers short, her ears standing out proudly and prominently in the pixie cut.

"What"?

"How do you know you're a girl"?

That was a weird question. "I dunno." She rolled onto her stomach, kicking her legs back and forth. Finn was flopped dramatically in the beanbag chair across the room. "Because Mom and Mama said I am"?

Finn fidgeted uncomfortable. "They said I'm a boy ."

Callie tilted her head, curious. "Are you really a girl? Like Aunt Perfuma"?

"I dunno." Finn shrugged. "I dont feel like a girl, either . Do *you* feel like a girl"?

"I guess." Callie kicked her legs a little harder. "I mean, I don't feel like I should be anything else. Uncle Bow said he always knew he was supposed to be a boy, right? I don't feel like that."

Finn's ears drooped. Mama said he looked like a kicked puppy sometimes. "Maybe something's wrong with me?" Grandma Cyra and Grandma Lyra were always talking about how wonderful and unique Callie and Finn were, being the children of a magicat and a werewolf. What if this was a *bad* unique?

"Nothing's wrong with you, dummy." Callie waved him off. "You feel how you feel. You should ask Mom and Mama—"

"No!"

The outburst surprised Callie. She jumped, fur on end, tail going stiff. "Why not?" she asked, bewildered.

"What if they're mad?"

Callie scoffed. "They wouldn't be *mad*. It's not like you peed on the carpet or anything."

"But what if they *are*?" Finn sniffled, clearly trying to hold back tears. "Mom says how proud she is of her *son* and her *little boy* all the time. But what if I'm not her little boy? What if it makes her sad?"

"Callie, Finn!" Catra called up the stairs, interrupting the conversation. "Dinner's ready!"

"She's not gonna be sad, Finny," Callie insisted. "She'll be sad if *you're* sad."

"But I'm not sad."

"Am I talking to myself?" Catra called again. "Mom's gonna eat all the food if you don't get down here."

"Please don't tell them," Finn begged. Callie sighed.

"You're being stupid. But fine."

"Hey Uncle Bow?"

Bow looked up from the bow he was re-stringing. Callie had taken a liking to archery, and loved going to the range with him whenever she could. "What's up?"

Callie was focusing very hard on the target in front of her as she spoke. Her eyes may have been all Adora, but their abilities were all Catra ~~-sh~~e had sharp sight and incredible aim. She waited for a moment before loosing the arrow;it hit the target, right in the middle, with a satisfying *thwack*.

"Is there something that isn't being a boy or a girl?"

Not the question Bow had expected. He watched Callie knock another arrow into place and take aim again. "There's a few things," he said slowly. "Why?"

Another loosed arrow, another bullseye. "Just curious."She shrugged, looking at him. "What things are there?"

Bow gestured for them to take a seat at a nearby bench. Callie set her bow aside and walked over, hopping up and waiting for her uncle to join her. "Well, there's nonbinary,"he started. "That means you don't identify as a boy *or* a girl. Or gender-fluid, which means you change what you identify as depending on...well, a lot of things, but mostly how you're feeling. You could feel like a girl, then feel like a boy again."

Nonbinary sounded more like how Finn felt. Callie felt a rush of pride. She'd helped her brother!"Why is nonbinary dif ferent?"

"Some people use dif ferent pronouns."Callie tilted her head in confusion. "I refer to you as she and her, right?"Those are pronouns. Some nonbinary people use they and them. And they don't always

like gendered terms being used to describe them —son or daughter , niece or nephew, stuff like that."

Oh, Finn might not want to be her brother anymore. That was okay. There was probably a regular word for brother and sister, right?

She was *so* excited to get home and talk to him.

"Finn! *Finn*!"

The pup on Finn's bed jerked away with a yelp, dazzling blue eyes blinking rapidly as Callie ran into the room. He gave a disgruntled, "*bruff*" at the rude interruption.

"I know , but I found out something amazing!" Callie threw herself onto Finn's bed. "There' s a *word* for not feeling like a boy or a girl."

Finn made a grumble-y noise before changing back. "What d'ya mean?"

"You said you don't feel like a boy or a girl, right?" Finn nodded. "There' s a *word* for it! It' s called nonbinary!"

Finn narrowed his eyes, frowning. "Where'd you find that?"

"Well." Callie fiddled with the hem of her t-shirt. "I asked Uncle Bow, but"—

"You *told* Uncle Bow?!" Finn didn't yell much. He was really quiet. They? Callie was sure if Finn would just *listen*— "You promised!"

She had only promised not to tell Mom or Mama, but Finn probably wouldn't like that answer . "I know , but Finny"—

"What if Uncle Bow tells Mom and Mama?"

"He wouldn't do that," Callie insisted. Uncle Bow had covered up *way* worse things. Like letting them stay up passed their bedtime when

he babysat. And that time Callie ate too much ice cream and got sick.

"But what if he *does*"?

"He *won't*!" Callie threw her hands up in frustration. "That's not the *point*, Finn, the point is there's a word!"

"You were supposed to keep it secret!"

Finn stomped passed Callie, out of the room, leaving his bewildered sister behind. "Fine!" she yelled after him, slamming the door. Why was he so *mean*? She threw herself onto her bed, bristling.

She stayed like that for a long time, until someone knocked on the door, and Catra poked her head in. "You uh...wanna tell me why your brother is tearing up pillows in the living room"?

"Because he's *stupid*," Callie huffed. "I was just trying to help and he's *mad* at me."

"Okay." Catra slid into the room, sitting beside Callie and gently scratching the base of her ear. A little purr bubbled up in her chest. "Why is he mad at you"?

"Cause he told me… *something*, and I was trying to help, so I asked Uncle Bow, and now he's mad at me even though I found out something really cool!"

"Okay." Catra brushed her fingers through Callie's hair. "Is something *wrong*"?

"I don't *think* so. But he's being dumb."

"Hey, be nice," Catra scolded. "You don't call your brother dumb." Callie harumphed, curling up tighter on her bed. "I'm not going to ask what's going on, because clearly Finn doesn't want to talk about it. And I get wanting to help him – you're just like your mother. You like

to fix things. But sometimes you have to let other people control what they do and don't tell everyone else."

"I didn't tell Uncle Bow *why* I was asking, though. And he helped! But Finn won't listen!"

That would be the part of Finn that was *very* Catra. "Maybe he's a little confused. Either way, you have to wait for him to want to talk."

Callie huffed, ears flat against her head. "I was trying to *help*."

"I know, sweetie."

They heard playful growls downstairs. Catra rolled her eyes. "Mom's home. Come on. Maybe we can sort this out."

Adora had decided to give Finn a more constructive outlet, letting him play stalk her around the living room. He jumped at her, gnawing on her leg, and she chuffed in amusement. "Finn," Catra called as she led Callie into the room. "Can we talk?"

Finn's ears went down; he whimpered, looking at Adora, who looked at Catra in turn. She shrugged. "No one is in trouble. But it sounds like there's some stuff we should work out." Finn growled, glaring at Callie. "She didn't tell me anything. But I'd like it if you would."

Finn huffed, walking to the couch and trying to jump up. Adora gives him a small nudge to help him onto the cushion. "Are you in trouble?" Finn shook his head. "Are you scared to tell us whatever it is?" A nod. "Do you think we'll be mad?" A long moment of hesitation, and then a nod. Adora nuzzled him with her snout, making a reassuring noise. "You know nothing you do could ever make us that mad at you, right?" Catra scratched his ears, giving him a reassuring smile. "We love you. If there's something we can do to help, you can tell us. And I know you're mad at Callie for talking to Uncle Bow about it, but...cut her some slack. She just wants to help you too."

Callie had curled her legs up to her chest, watching Finn uncertainly. He stared back, then climbed over Catra's lap and tackled Callie, licking her face. She screeched. "Eeeeeewwww , get off!" She batted at him half-heartedly as he made sure each and every inch of her face was thoroughly licked before abruptly changing back and falling on her. "Are you still mad at me?" she asked after a minute. Finn shrugged.

"A little. But it' s okay."

Adora changed back to scoop Finn up, cradling him a bit. "So do you want to tell *us* what's going on?"

Finn fidgeted uncomfortably, staring at the ground. "Y ou promise you wont be mad?"

"Not unless you like, lit something on fire."

"And even that we could forgive depending on circumstances."

Adora glared at Catra over Finn's head. She winked in returned. Finn huffed, burying his face in Adora's shoulder. "I dont feel like a boy ," he mumbled, almost inaudibly. "But I dont feel like a girl. I dont wanna be either."

Ah. That was definitely an understandable source of anxiety. "So you dont think you're like Aunt Perfuma?" Adora asked. Finn shook his head.

"Can I say what Uncle Bow told me?" Callie asked, raising a hand. Finn looked at warily, then nodded. "He said lots of stuf f, but there was one that really sounded like what Finn told me. It was.um"… The word had completely escaped her in all the chaos. "No-something?"

"Nonbinary?" Catra guessed. Callie lit up.

"Yeah, that! And he said that people use different pronouns – like, instead of Finn being he, Finn would be they, and they don't always like gendered terms. Is there a regular word for brother and sister?"

"Sibling," Adora supplied.

"So Finn would be my sibling, not my brother."

Catra looked at Finn, who was still curled in Adora's arms. "What do you think, bud? Does that sound right?"

"You're not mad?" he asked in a small voice. Adora hugged him tight, while Catra kissed his cheek.

"Of course not. We want you to be happy. But you need to tell us how to make that happen."

He wiggled uncertainly. "I guess... that nothing feels right."

"Nonbinary?"

"Yeah."

"What about pronouns? Do you want to be they instead of he?"

Finn considered it for a long, long moment. "Do I have to pick right now?"

"Of course not. You can take as much time as you need."

"We can also just test it around the house," Adora suggested. "So me, Mama, and Callie would call you they, but you'd still be he at school and with your grandparents and aunts and uncles – unless you want to tell them."

Finn's entire expression lit up. "Like having a secret identity?"

"A little bit, yeah."

"Can we do that?"

Catra and Adora exchanged fond smiles over Finn's head. "Sure," Catra said. "So you want to be they when we're home?"

Finn nodded eagerly. "All right then." Adora hoisted them into the air Lion King-style. "I hereby declare you *them*, effective immediately, until you tell us otherwise."

"Mooooooooooooooooooooooooom." Finn giggled. They already seemed happier, like a weight had been lifted off their shoulders.

"Okay , okay, no more Lion King reenactments," Catra said, biting down a smile. "Finn, Callie, go get cleaned up for dinner . And be ready to clean up the pillow stuffing after so Grandma Cyra can make new ones."

It had been a simple, yet ingenious suggestion. Have pillows specifically for the kids to rip up. Marlena and Randor had apparently done it with Adora, and it had saved a *lot* of furniture.

"Race you," Callie challenged, jumping up and darting for the stairs.

"No fair!" Finn yelled, running after her .It was Callie's turn to be outraged when they changed at the bottom of the stairs and bounded up on four legs, barely beating Callie to the top.

"Cheater!"

"You started it!"

Catra looked at Adora, who was smiling.

"Number one moms?" she asked. Catra grinned.

"Hell yeah."

Someone Who Cares

Chapter Summary

Catra and Glimmer bonding time

Chapter Notes

Few notes for this one:

-It's during Catra's first year of college, when she and Glimmer are sharing a dorm together. Adora is still "dead"
-Still some pretty heavy mourning going on (but Catra is slowly learning to move on)
-Bow and Glimmer are disaster bisexuals
-tw for alcohol use and vague suicidal ideation

"Catra! W ake up!"

Her eyes shot open with a yelp, claws automatically sweeping out. Luckily, Glimmer had learned the art of ducking. "Hey , it's okay," she said soothingly, resting a hand on Catra's shoulder. "Y oure okay ."

Catra sucked in a few sharp breaths, pressing her hand to her chest. "Does it hurt?" Glimmer asked qietly . Catra nodded once, staring at the wall straight ahead. "Okay . Budge."

She moved on automatic, shifting closer to the wall so Glimmer could climb into bed with her. They had developed a routine during their time living together. Glimmer was nearly an expert at helping Catra deal with her nightmares. It was impressive.

Glimmer crawled under the covers, settling down beside Catra;she raised a hand, bringing some dancing lights to life.The soft, violet hue always helped Catra relax. It felt a little like the meditation techniqes Perfuma had tried to teach her .

"Tell me a story," Glimmer prompted after a moment. Catra frowned, wracking her brain to try and think of a good one.

"Would you believe Adora and I never had sex?"

Glimmer coughed, trying to choke back a laugh. "*Really*? How long were you guys together?"

"A couple years." But their entire lives. "We kissed and stuff, and some of the make out sessions got a little heated, but...yeah, it never went any further than maybe taking our shirts off. Is that weird?"

"Is it that you didn't *want* to have sex with Adora, or just that the idea of it wasn't as thrilling to you?"

"The second one, I think. I didn't really care how I had Adora...as long as I had her. And I really did *always* have her." Catra chuckled weakly, closing her eyes. "You know, we got into kind of a...I don't want to say fight, because it was mostly me overreacting and lashing out when she made a fully human friend. And you know what she said?"

"What'd she say?"

"That she'd rather be a wolf with me than a human with anyone else. We were seven, and I think I already knew I was in love with her."

Glimmer snuggled a little closer to Catra's side, offering her some warmth. There was absolutely nothing romantic between them — there could have been, maybe, if Catra wasn't still in mourning and Glimmer wasn't so clearly in love with Bow. But they were friends. It was a friendship that made Catra feel warm and safe. Something she hadn't experienced in a long time.

"Sometimes I...I don't know. I wonder if she's really dead. I *know* she is." Nothing could keep Adora away if she were alive. Catra was well aware of that. "But it's like she's...somewhere waiting for me."

"Do you think about that a lot?" Glimmer asked carefully. There'd been discussions (mostly drunken discussions) about Catra's mental health and her loose relationship with the idea of living. It wasn't a subject to be broached if she was sober.

"No. Yes. Maybe." Catra sighed, squeezing her eyes shut. "Maybe it's just a weird bond thing, or maybe I just can't imagine life without her. It's only been three years and it *hurts*, and I... how am I supposed to live the rest of my life like this?"

Glimmer was quiet for a moment, watching her dancing lights. "My dad's mom died when I was six or seven. His dad lived for another ten years, and I know it was hard on him. They were married for almost fifty years, her suddenly not being there was traumatic. I wasn't supposed to hear about any of that, of course, but I snuck around, picked up bits of conversation. I heard him telling my dad once that it was just one day at a time. Looking at the entire future is scary and unpredictable, but if you focus on what you can do right now, on this day, this hour, this minute, it's a little easier. You don't have to think about all the possible what ifs. Just think about what you need to get through the next hour."

Catra blew out a long breath, opening her eyes again. "I think I need sleeping pills to get through the next hour. And the hour after that. And every hour until my alarm goes off at eight."

Glimmer sat up slightly to check the clock. It was just after two. That was enough time, probably. She slid out of bed, found the pill bottle, and grabbed a bottle of water. "You okay alone?" she asked as she brought the stuff back. Catra gave the wall a little more attention than it really needed before she took the pills and shook her head.

"No. I don't think I am."

That was Glimmer's cue to crawl back into bed and tug the blankets up. Melog was pressed against Catra's other side, completing the sandwich. It wasn't too bad, she thought as she slowly drifted back

to sleep, lulled half by the sleeping pills and half by Glimmer's even breathing. At least she didn't have to deal with things alone.

Catra hated it when Glimmer left for the weekend.

She had a standing invitation and her own room at Glimmer's parents' house, whether Glimmer was there or not, and she had taken them up on that offer once or twice when she *really* didn't trust herself alone (and she was getting better at recognizing those days). Angella and Micah were perfectly nice and clearly suffering some intense empty nest syndrome, and it made Catra feel a little better about her moms being too far away for a casual visit.

But she was fine this weekend. Lonely, but fine. Glimmer had gone to visit Bow, and Catra was taking some time to get ahead on her schoolwork - she loved having assignments listed out in advance. It gave her a cushion when she inevitably hit another slump and couldn't do anything but stare at the ceiling for three days. She was getting better slowly. Being away from Half Moon and the memories helped in some ways. It gave her space. She couldn't randomly drive by the empty lot that used to be Adora's house, or go to any of their hang out places, or run through the woods, taking all the same paths they had run together. The city offered less in the way of places to just casually be a werecat, but Glimmer and Bow were introducing her to state parks. They were an okay alternative, even if she had to drive to get to them.

Melog was acting as her pillow, letting her rest against them while they snoozed on the bed. Catra's emotions had been pretty baseline all day, and the mental hum had lulled them into relaxation. There was brief spike of irritation every now and again, but it was only schoolwork. A basic human thing that Melog couldn't help with.

Then they felt the flash of pain. They sat up as Catra leaned forward, hand pressed against her chest. She did her best to breathe through it. It was all she could do.

Cyra and Lyra had been concerned, of course, when they're teenage daughter started experiencing random chest pains. They took her to at least three different doctors to try and find a cause, but as far as anyone could tell, she was perfectly healthy. It had been Lyra who started to suspect it was mental rather than physical, and had found a magicat psychologist who specialized in helping magicats deal with broken bonds.

A broken heart. Catra hated the term, but it was the best description the psychologist had. Every magicat who lost their bond partner experienced the same thing – the same, sharp pain that stole their breath away and erased the world around them for the briefest moment. There was no treatment. Therapy could help *lessen* the pain, but it was always there, always lurking and waiting for a moment to strike.

Melog mewled, brushing their nose against Catra's hand. She carefully unclenched the fist that had formed around her shirt and reached out to pet Melog's snout. It was fine. Everything she was fine. She just had a broken fucking heart. No big deal.

Catra slumped against Melog, squeezing her eyes shut. People had stopped saying it would get easier, at least. She may learn to live — she *would* learn to live – but it was never going to be easy. Not like it had been with Adora. But that was a high bar to meet.

The dorm room door opened. Catra sat up to see Glimmer walking in, slightly dazed. "Um...you okay?" No answer. "Earth to Glimmer, *hello*. Anybody home?"

Glimmer blinked a few times, turning to look at Catra. Her voice was slightly hoarse as she spoke. "I uh...I kissed Bow."

Screw homework. *This* was the distraction Catra needed. "*What*?" She threw her book aside, leaning forward eagerly. "When? Where?"

"Um...twenty seconds ago? In his car. He just dropped me off and I...I don't know, I kissed him."

"Wait, if it just happened...did you kiss him and *run away*?"

"I said thank you first!" Glimmer's voice was nearly shrill. Catra slapped a hand to her forehead.

"You're fucking useless. Come on."

Catra jumped off the bed, grabbing Glimmer's arm and dragging her back to the door. "Wait, where are we going?"

"*You* are going to talk to Bow."

"What if he's already left?"

If Catra rolled her eyes any harder, they'd probably fall out of her head. "If he's already left, then he's an even bigger idiot than you are."

He had *not* left, of course. He was sitting right where he had been, looking rather dazed and bewildered. When Catra yanked open the car door, shoved Glimmer in, and said, "Talk this out while I get dinner," before closing the door and heading for the student center.

"I can't believe Sea Hawk's trying to pledge a fraternity."

"I can't believe his singing hasn't gotten him kicked out yet."

Catra was about ninety percent positive Sea Hawk didn't *actually* want to join the fraternity—he'd have to stay in the frat house, and god forbid he be away from Mermista—but he wanted the *adventure* of going through the pledging process.

"Maybe he's funnier when his audience is drunk?" Catra guessed, taking a sip of her drink. It was a lowkey party, loud enough to not be boring (and to cover up Sea Hawk's singing), but not so quiet that it was dull. Catra and Mermista could stand against the wall and watch the goings on without anyone bothering them.

"That has *definitely* not been my experience."

"Why do you date him again?"

Mermista shrugged, throwing back the rest of her drink. "I dont know, I love him or something." She tipped her cup in Catra' s direction. "How've you been?"

It was as close to sincere as Mermista could possibly get, and Catra knew it was hard for her. She expressed herself through groans and exasperated outbursts. Having an honest conversation was hard.

"Okay ." Catra shrugged, letting out a long breath. "Been dreaming a lot, but that's nothing new. Roommate's really helping."

"Is she still coming? Scorpia asked me to make sure she' s good for you."

"Oh, *Scorpia* asked, huh?"

"Y up, I've got the Facebook message to prove it."

And Scorpia was absolutely, definitely the *only* concerned person. "She should be here soon." Catra checked her phone and found an *on my way* message from Glimmer that had come in about ten minutes ago. "Her parents do Friday night dinners, and they're about half an hour away."

Mermista went to take a sip of her drink, then remembered her cup was empty; she dragged Catra with her to get another one. "I *so* do not miss family dinners. Getting out of Half Moon was the best thing we ever did."

"Y eah," Catra agreed with a half-hearted shrug. "I miss my moms sometimes."

Mermista filled her cup, then refilled Catra's. "I mean, yeah, but your moms are cool."

"Oh my god, *please* dont tell them that. Itll go right to their heads."

"It' s true, though. You, Scorpia, and Adora definitely have the best parents in our group." *have*. Present tense. Mermista realized her mistake as pain flickered through Catra's eyes. "Shit. Im sorry, I—"

"No, it' s.it' s fine," Catra mumbled, taking a long sip of her drink. "Y oure right, Marlena and Randor were amazing."

She missed them too. But if she let herself think about it too much, shed drown. "Anyway, yeah, Glimmer's cool. I think youll like her."

"As long as she doesnt need a beating or anything, well be good."

Catra rolled her eyes, feeling a little better.

She was well on her way to drunk by the time Glimmer finally arrived. "Hey!" Glimmer said cheerfully, wrapping Catra in a quick hug before turning to Mermista. "Y oure Mermista, right? Im Glimmer."

"Nice to meet you. Im not a hugger."

"Neither is Catra, she' s just given up."

"Im just getting you to let your guard down," Catra grumbled. "Ill get you when youre not expecting it."

"Uh huh." Glimmer smiled patiently. "Im going to get a drink. Y ou guys need a refill?"

"Please," Catra chirped while Mermista nodded.

"Okay, she's all right so far," Mermista concluded when Glimmer was out of earshot. "The hugging thing is a bit much."

"She' s also violent," Catra pointed out helpfully. "She' s always ready to punch someone."

"*That* I can get on board with."

Glimmer returned with drinks, laughing. "Do you guys see that weirdo with the mustache? I think he's singing *sea shanties*."

"Yeah," Mermista said, groaning. "That's uh...that's my boyfriend. Sometimes."

"*Really*?"

"It's a whole thing. Dont ask."

"Nononono *do* ask," Catra insisted. "Ask her about the eighth grade dance."

"*Please* dont ask about that. It was so stupid."

"But we were a *great* couple."

They left a little after midnight, Catra slumped on Glimmer and giggling slightly as she tried to sing one of Sea Hawk's shanties. "You want help?" Mermista asked. Sea Hawk was staying for a bit longer, but she need a break and some fresh air. Glimmer looked at her drunken roommate, and sighed.

"Please."

Mermista took Catra's other arm, pulling it over her shoulders. "Come on kitty cat. Time to get you to bed. Where's Melog?"

"They dont like parties," Catra said with a pout. "The alcohol makes them feel weird."

"Catra being drunk has some kind of affect on them," Glimmer explained. "They came with us to one party and Catra nearly tripped over them on the way home because they couldnt walk straight. Im sure the hangover this time is going to be *great*."

Melog was curled up in a nest at the end of Catra's bed. They raised their head in acknowledgment as the girls entered the room, then nestled back in to sleep. "In you go," Mermista huffed, shoving Catra into bed. She was purring and smiling as Glimmer tucked her in.

"Ghight Glimmer. Night Mista."

"Sleep well, Catra," Glimmer said, patting her head. She looked back at Mermista, who nodded her head toward the door. Glimmer followed her out into the hall.

"Thanks," Mermista said when the door closed. "For...taking care of her. I tried to get her to move in with me and Sea Hawk, but she wanted to do things on her own, and...how much has she told you?"

"Most things, I assume?" Glimmer shrugged. "She told me about Adora and...the fire and everything. I know she's still really messed up from it."

Mermista nodded slowly. "Most things, yeah. She seems to like you, though. And...I'm glad. She needs someone who doesn't also have the baggage—Adora was our friend, losing her was hard on all of us. It was just...the hardest on Catra, obviously. We weren't really sure she was going to make it for awhile." There was something dark in her eyes as she thought about those first few weeks, before Catra had run away and after she had come home. It really had been terrifying. And none of them had known what to do. "But you seem like you know what you're doing and how to deal with her, and… well, thanks."

Glimmer smiled. "She's my friend. I'll do whatever I can to help her. And if I can't, at least I know there's an expert nearby who can help."

"Right, let me get your number." ...Mermista pulled her phone, tapping away on it for a minute. "No pressure, but she's got a lot of people who care about her and want her to be okay."

I can handle it,” Glimmer said confidently . A small smile twitched at Mermista’s lips. This one might just work out after all.

End Notes

As always, you can find me on Tumblr (catrasredemption) or Twitter (catraredeemed), and yell at me for the feelings I may cause. I'll also take suggestions for what to write about here - I can't promise to use every single prompt I get, but the inspiration would be nice.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!